

PHOTO FINISH

From drive-by birthday parades and plasma donors to pop-up pantries and doorstep deliveries, the people in this country are doing amazing things to love one another. And it's contagious! Farica West, principal of Poplar Springs High School in Graceville, Florida, desperately wanted to recognize her school's graduating seniors, who had missed out on much of their senior year and memorable moments. West said she struggled for weeks to come up with an idea to celebrate the seniors.

West decided to place a poster-sized photo of each senior along the school's front driveway. A local photographer enlarged the photos. Then West and her husband and son attached the photos to posts and placed them on both sides of the driveway.

Ripple Effect

With the graduates' photos adorning the entryway to the school property, students and their families could come by, take pictures, and feel celebrated. Some people hugged family members they had come with, and some cried. Other members of the community took notice of the photos and couldn't stay away.

Word eventually spread and Principal West began hearing from appreciative people around the country and beyond. Even people who didn't have a child at the school came from other states to see the display. West said that people from New Zealand, Australia, and Nova Scotia asked her for end-of-year celebration tips.

We All Do

It feels good when we can make a difference in someone else's life. Deep down we all can feel that tug, a Holy Spirit nudge, urging us to use our energy to bring about good. Principal West demonstrated that we all can do something where we are right now. Although we are going through a time of sadness and reflection, we can do something to make others happy.

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urging us to use our energy to bring about good.**



TIP FOR THIS ISSUE

Today, you will have an opportunity to remind your community about the heart of God. Jesus showed us how to live as a servant, giving his love, attention, healing touch, and saving life for our good. Serving seems like a chore to some people; but when we do something tangible, we connect our head, heart, and spirit. Challenge your students to identify those in need and to allow God to guide them in ministry. Try to offer a voice of reason and safety without squelching any excitement. Remember that God will work for good in all our efforts.

TEACHER BIBLE PREP

SERVING IN A TIME OF NEED

Question of the Day: How can we serve those in need around us?

Purpose: To encourage creative expressions of faith through service

Cultural Connection: Principal decorates school's front driveway with large portraits of graduates

Topic: Servanthood

TO SERVE AND TO GIVE

Matthew 20:20-28

Whoever wants to be first among you will be your slave—just as the Human One didn't come to be served but rather to serve and to give his life to liberate many people. —Matthew 20:27-28

Commentary:

Two of the disciples were jockeying for greater position, with a little help from their mother. Jesus' response to them showed that, once again, they did not fully understand who Jesus was and what his mission was all about. They believed that Jesus would be the Savior of Israel, but their hope was limited to a temporal, political revolution. Therefore, their play for power in his coming kingdom showed a desire for recognition and authority. However, Jesus' mission, the one that we are still carrying out, can be embodied only through selfless service.

Questions to think about:

- ▶ Putting yourself in the disciples' shoes, how would you have felt if two of your friends were making power moves and trying to leave you out? Can you think of a time when you've experienced something similar?
- ▶ What did Jesus mean when he said he came to serve and not be served? How was that possible?

FREE FROM...

Galatians 5:13-15

You were called to freedom, brothers and sisters; only don't let this freedom be an opportunity to indulge your selfish impulses, but serve each other through love. —Galatians 5:13



Commentary:

The apostle Paul wrote to the churches in southern Galatia, whom he had met while on his first missionary journey. Paul was concerned about the divisions between the Jewish and Gentile followers. The two groups disagreed about what true discipleship looked like and were beginning to tear apart the community. Freedom or license to sin is not really freedom, because it actually enchains you to evil, other people, or your own sinful nature. Christians should not be slaves to sin, because they are free to do what is right and to glorify God through loving service to others.

Questions to think about:

- ▶ Freedom is tricky business. We all want freedom, but many of us don't use it wisely. When have you gotten yourself in trouble with too much freedom?
- ▶ Serving others in need doesn't sound like freedom. How would you explain this idea to someone who is not a Christian?

TEACHER BIBLE PREP

ON FIRE

Romans 12:9-15

Love should be shown without pretending. Hate evil, and hold on to what is good. Love each other like the members of your family. Be the best at showing honor to each other. Don't hesitate to be enthusiastic—be on fire in the Spirit as you serve the Lord! Be happy in your hope, stand your ground when you're in trouble, and devote yourselves to prayer. Contribute to the needs of God's people, and welcome strangers into your home. —Romans 12:9-13

Commentary:

The apostle Paul urged the Christians in Rome to get rid of pretense and learn how to truly love. Pure love takes attention and effort. It means helping others become better people. These type of efforts demand our time, money, and personal energies. A servant's heart shows through generosity, hospitality, and sacrificial love.

Questions to think about:

- ▶ Why do we need to show others we care?
- ▶ What happens when we lose hope? How can we regain hope?
- ▶ What's the most inspiring way you've heard of someone serving others over the past few months?

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DEVOTION: LET'S SERVE JESUS

Hospitality is a gift that crosses all language and cultural barriers. Over the past 25 years, I have truly been blessed to receive the welcome of strangers all over the world. Humble Christ followers were always eager to offer their homes, local cuisine, and genuine conversation. They even opened their own homes to visiting missionaries. In Honduras, Moscow, Nicaragua, the Appalachian Mountains (here in the United States), Nicaragua, the Bahamas, and even rural Sierra Leone, the language of love often looks the same. New friends would greet us with genuine smiles and open arms.

God gives us the same ability to offer our resources and energy to someone who could use encouragement or assistance. Serving doesn't have to be complicated.



We just have to put others before our own needs, fears, or hesitations. In doing so, we may actually be serving Jesus—just as he taught in Matthew 25:40: “I assure you that when you have done it for one of the least of these brothers and sisters of mine, you have done it for me.”

NEXT WEEK: Pentecost brings renewal and restores hope in the story of the early church. Next week in LiNC we'll talk about celebrating and experiencing the Holy Spirit in difficult times.

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LiNC
LIVING IN CHRIST

PUTTING OTHERS FIRST



Getting Ready: Arrange a day and time for your group to video conference and, if possible, send the link a few days prior to the meeting. Suggest students read all the Scripture passages and gather the following items before your video call begins: a Bible or Bible app, paper, pen or pencil.

Before the Session: Email Youth Page 6 to the teens. Ask the them to write the numbers 1 to 24 randomly in the squares on the Bingo card, but not to number the heart square. Tell them to leave room to write in the squares. Invite each teen to come up with a list of ways they could serve a neighbor (anyone in your community), and then send them to you. Pick 24 of your group's suggestions and number them. Email the numbered list to the teens, and ask them to write the ways to serve in the corresponding numbered spaces on the Bingo card. Create a list of chores (see "House List").

OPEN

House List (10 minutes)

Invite your group to make a list of all the chores that could be done in and around a home. Give them 30 seconds to write their list. Create your own list ahead of time, and include chores they might not think of. This could include wiping down baseboards, dusting the fans or window shades/blinds, deep cleaning the toilets, mopping the bathroom floor, doing laundry, taking out the trash, helping a sibling with chores, cooking dinner, and washing and vacuuming a car.

After the time is up, see who listed the most chores. Then find out everything they wrote down. Ask the group:

- ▶ Which chore on your list would shock your parent the most if he or she came home to find you had done it?
- ▶ Which chore could you do the fastest? Which would take you the most time?
- ▶ Which chore would bring the most appreciation from your whole family?

Wrap up by saying: "Serving is not always glamorous or fun. In fact, it's often more exciting to serve someone outside our own home. But, no matter where we do our helping, as long as love is our motivator, good will come from it!"

EXPLORE

Talk Topic 1: The Heart of Serving (10 minutes)

Middle School Option

Invite teens to open their Bible or Bible app to Matthew 20:20-28, and ask a volunteer to read aloud. Use the

commentary and questions in "To Serve and to Give" in the Teacher Bible Prep to get everyone's honest thoughts about the Scripture. Then ask the following questions.

- ▶ If Jesus were cleaning your house, which chores would he do? Which chores would you try to prevent Jesus from doing?
- ▶ Are you good at working hard? Why or why not?

Say: "It seems like Jesus is saying that life is not about getting ahead. As his followers, we need to put the needs of others first. And that is so challenging!"

High School Option

Invite teens to open their Bible or Bible app to Matthew 20:20-28, and ask a volunteer to read aloud. Read the commentary and questions in "To Serve and to Give" in the Teacher Bible Prep. Here are a few more questions to help the conversation go deeper:

- ▶ How does the gift of Jesus' life actually liberate people (free them from disorganized priorities and help them pursue a life of purpose, not simply their own desires)?
- ▶ Think of a time when you had to work especially hard on a sizable task or project. Do you remember how you felt once it was completed?

Say: "Doing work can bring rewards, and that's even more true when we are spending our time, energy, and resources on something that we believe God has called us to do."

Talk Topic 2: Don't Indulge (15 minutes)

Middle School Option

Say: "Dream buffet! You just arrived at a brand-new, magical restaurant where world-class chefs have prepared anything and everything, and you can sample it all for free. What's more, the dessert table is 50 feet long and includes every dessert, candy, and treat you can imagine. What main dishes would get your attention first? What tempting dishes would make you want to go back for more? And what about dessert—which treats would you fill your plate up with?"

Ask:

- ▶ When you're at a really good buffet, why is it so difficult not to overindulge?
- ▶ How is a buffet similar to the life we've been living the past few months?

SAY: "Now, let's connect this delicious scenario to our topic today." Invite teens to open their Bible or Bible app to Galatians 5:13-15, and ask a volunteer to read aloud. Then

PUTTING OTHERS FIRST



read the commentary and questions in “Free From...” in the Teacher Bible Prep. Ask:

- ▶ How much free time did you have before the pandemic? In comparison, how much have you had recently?
- ▶ During the pandemic, we haven’t had certain freedoms we are used to having. Which ones have been most difficult not to have?

Use the “Combined Transition” (after “High School Option”) to transition to the next activity.

High School Option

Say: “Streaming binge! Let’s say you are stuck inside a vacation house for an entire week because of bad weather. The only thing you can do is stream movies or shows. Fortunately, the house has every possible show and movie available to stream, commercial-free. What movie marathon or series would you stream first? At what point will you get bored, if ever? What might you refuse to watch?”

Transition by saying: “You’re back from your dream vacation. Let’s read our Scripture and see how this all relates.” Invite teens to open their Bible or Bible app to Galatians 5:13-15, and ask a volunteer to read aloud. Read the commentary and questions in “Free From...” in the Teacher Bible Prep. Ask:

- ▶ It’s fairly natural for us to be self-indulgent if we can’t get out of our house. How have you indulged in the past few months—binging on shows, spending too much time on TikTok or other social media, sleeping more, or snacking too much?
- ▶ What could be healthy goals for you? What or who could help you keep those goals?

Use the “Combined Transition” to move to the next activity.

Combined Transition

Conclude by saying: “It’s important to remember that during this quarantine, many of us have indulged beyond our normal boundaries, and for good reason. Some of us are dealing with substantial loss, so we simply are coping the best we can. And yet, some of us just don’t know how to care for others. Part of growing up is learning how to put others first.”

BONUS SMALL GROUP DISCUSSION

Wash Those Feet

Invite teens to open their Bible or Bible app to John 13:1-20. You may read about Jesus washing the disciples’ feet or watch a video. If you choose to read the Scripture, ask a volunteer to read it aloud. Or play the video at <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=yRTjb4tYKZ4>, and invite your students to follow along in their Bible as they watch. Share your screen and audio so that everyone can watch simultaneously. After reading from the Bible or watching the video, discuss the following questions:

- ▶ Did anything in the story surprise you?
- ▶ Why did Jesus wash the disciples’ feet?
- ▶ We don’t have this custom in today’s world, because we usually wear socks and shoes. What could this look like in modern times?
- ▶ How is God calling us to radical service, particularly at this unique time?

Talk Topic 3: Should Be Shown (15 minutes)

Combined Middle School and High School Option

Say: “Finding ways to serve our neighbors can be a bit challenging with so many changing restrictions and potential hazards. We want to be smart and safe, and yet not let fear keep us from making a difference around us.”

If you haven’t already, read today’s cultural connection on page 1 for an inspiring story. Then ask your students if they filled out the Bingo card on Youth Page 6. If not, ask them to do it later. Challenge the teens to work to complete the card during the week ahead.

Invite teens to open their Bible or Bible app to Romans 12:9-15, and ask a volunteer to read aloud. Read the commentary and questions in “On Fire” in the Teacher Bible Prep. Ask:

- ▶ When have you been on the receiving end of sacrificial hospitality and generosity?
- ▶ Who do you know who is great at serving others?
- ▶ What’s the biggest barrier to serving others right now?

TAKE AWAY

Loving and serving are the best ways to bring about hope and joy in ourselves and in our world. Now more than ever, our actions can bring about change!

WORKING IT OUT

NEIGHBOR BINGO

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Before your group's video conference, write the numbers 1 to 24 randomly in the squares on the Bingo card, but don't number the one with the heart. Leave plenty of room to write, as your leader will tell you what else to write in the squares.

Will you get more Bingos than your friends by next Sunday?
Can you complete your card?

In the Bible: Readings for the Week

MONDAY: Read 1 Kings 17:8-16.

How can I trust God to help me give all I can?

TUESDAY: Read 1 Corinthians 15:57-58.

God of grace, give me courage to work hard for you.

WEDNESDAY: Read Joshua 2:1-14.

How can I be helpful even to strangers or enemies?

THURSDAY: Read John 13:12-17.

God, humble me so that I may do the work of a servant and wash the feet of others.

FRIDAY: Read Luke 22:25-27.

God, if you came to earth to serve in love, then so can I.

SATURDAY: Read Daniel 3:14-18.

Lord, give me a determined faith never to serve the wrong gods.

Inherit the Mirth



WHAT'S TRENDING?

How are you finding unique ways to help others during this time of separation? Tweet or post your response with the hashtag #stillserving on Twitter to @YMPartners or on facebook.com/youthministrypartners